Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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Kashimiri Kashidakari carpet | © OlegD/Shutterstock

Unraveling the wonders of Kashmiri Embroidery

This week's HiH takes us to the North! Kashmir, with its beautiful natural landscapes and indigenous flora and fauna, continues to inspire poets and artists. Art is woven into Kashmir's traditions through its craft heritage.

Source: Current Conservation @ccmagazineindia

Namda: felted rugs



Ranjan, M. P., Ranjan, A. (2007). *Handmade in India*. Council of Handicraft Development Corporations.

Namda are felted rugs that are made by wetting and pressing wool fibres and subsequently embroidering them with the *ari* technique.

These rugs are used in Kashmir as an effective floor covering or as mattresses.

Gabba rugs from recycled blankets

Gabba rugs are created from recycled old woollen blankets stitched together and embroidered with crewel work. They often have nature-inspired motifs as well.



Ranjan, M. P., Ranjan, A. (2007). *Handmade in India*. Council of Handicraft Development Corporations.

Threading nature into cloth



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Kashmiri embroidery motifs are heavily drawn from nature. *Chinar* leaves, trees, flowers, birds and other animals are often depicted through delicate needlework.

Sozni: Delicate kashidakari



Sozni is a form of extremely delicate Kashmiri embroidery done primararily on *pashmina* shawls. The most common motifs used are *pamposh* (lotus), *chinar*, *badam* (almond); *dacch gurn* (grape leaf) and *duin* (the flower of the chinar tree).



Pashmina | © Notafish/Wikimedia Commons



Pashmina goat | © शंतनू/Wikimedia Commons

Pashmina wool

Pashmina, a type of fine and light-weight wool, obtained from the *Changthangi* breed of goat, is the most famous export of Kashmir. *Pashmina* garments with Kashmiri embroidery work are globally sought.

Techniques of Kashidakari

Ari is the most commonly used technique for *Kashidakari*. The thread is passed through the *ari*, a hooked needle which is used to pull the stitches through the fabric. Crewel work uses a thicker *ari* and thicker thread or wool is used to embroider the cloth.



Kashidakari: art using needles



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Kashidakari, or Kashmiri embroidery, literally translates to 'needle-work', and is a traditional form of embroidery, that originated in the Mughal period.

Sewing art onto fabric



Embroidery on a Kashmiri shawl (front) | © Kritzolina/Wikimedia Commons

Kashidakari artisans are adept at producing delicate embroidered designs, which require an eagle-eye and extreme patience.

The base of the fabric which is generally used is either silk or wool or cotton, however, since wool is commonly found in this region, it is preferably used.



Embroidery on a Kashmiri shawl (back) | © Kritzolina/Wikimedia Commons